

# Boys to men



What constitutes the rite of passage to adulthood for Australian males at the end of the millennium?

**Stephen Scourfield** speaks to a range of male experts, mentors, role models and fathers in a bid to find the answer.

Source: "Big Weekend",  
The West Australian",  
May 22, 1999.

FIRST BOOK OF CORINTHIANS:

*"When I was a child, I  
spoke as a child, I under-  
stood as a child, I thought  
as a child; but when I  
became a man, I put  
away childish things."*

FATHER Rohr speaks all over the world, and says that the subject he is most asked to tackle is men's spirituality and the move from being a boy to becoming a man. If he just spoke on this, he'd still be holding conferences and retreats every week, particularly in North America and Europe.

"Almost all of known civilisation, until the recent West, felt it necessary to initiate the boy, the assumption being that men were not born, they were made. And these were cultures entirely disconnected from one another. And the similarity of pattern of what they felt they had to teach the young man is absolutely amazing."

Father Rohr says that traditional cultures felt that if the boy was not initiated into manhood, he would always abuse power. He says there is a just assumption, especially from the women, "that if you give men power they will always use it for their own self-aggrandising ... promotion ... and not for service of the world."

"That's why every culture felt it necessary to teach the boy the language of descent — that's my word for it. If the boy is not taught the language of descent he will endlessly try to ascend." When the man is young he wants to climb. "He wants to become. It's called the Heroic Journey. He wants to be famous, rich — every young man is arguing about who's got the biggest." It's a macho thing, and Australian men are very macho, he believes.

But communities could be destroyed by all these self-serving young men ... "by men who didn't know how to use their gifts for the common good. But the man has to be taught the language of descent because he basically doesn't believe it."

(Father Rohr says women will generally experience descent first — fighting voices of inferiority, unimportance or insignificance — then ascend.)

Other cultures do, of course, still have male initiation procedures. Rites of passage. Father Rohr, who lives in New Mexico, in an area with an indigenous Navajo Indian population, incorporates the techniques from their religions.

"Cultures seemed to believe that you didn't move from Boy to Man, it was always Boy, Nature, Man." He had to be taken out of the world of "comfort and pseudo control and the world of women taking care of him and fussing over him", into the world of nature, where he would see the patterns that he could not control and could not deny. "And that became his great teacher."

Father Rohr says this is particularly applicable to untries like Australia, with its Outback.

Aboriginal boys traditionally went through Law — a ceremonial passage to manhood. In a published conversation between Joseph Campbell, the world's remotest authority on mythology before his death in '87, and eminent journalist Bill Moyers, Campbell says that while physical initiations are taking place, they are being shown enactments of mythological isodes from the great myths. They are instructed in the mythology of the tribe ... The boy has now come out as a man."

Interestingly, the conversation between Campbell and Moyers took place at Skywalker Ranch, the home of George Lucas, creator of Star Wars.

A senior Aboriginal man in Broome recently told me that going through Law is less common these days. He and other Aboriginal men we were talking with — in that getting into trouble, being locked up, has come a form of modern initiation rite. They even pressed concerns that our Deaths in Custody figures are tied in with this and a deeper need for a rite of passage.

"Although we have thrown initiation out of our mainstream learning the need is still there," says renowned Melbourne futurist Dr Peter Ellyard. "It was self-evident that during the transition to adulthood a process of initiation should be a major focus of education." He points to street gangs incorporating rituals and rites of passage into their cultures.

Dr Ellyard is executive director of Preferred Futures, a company which assists governments, corporations, trade unions and other organisations to "resee the requirements of the 21st Century. His new book, *Ideas for the New Millennium* (Melbourne University Press), includes some of his beliefs on the transition from boyhood to manhood.

In an address at a conference celebrating the education of boys in Catholic schools, he also intimated: "It is my view that boys and men in western developing countries are increasingly in trouble. In the 70s and 80s affirmative action programs were implemented for the education of girls ... however, I believe it is now time for similar attention to be directed towards the education of boys."

There is a dark side to the strange quest for manhood.

If males aged 15 to 24 who died in 1997, 31 per cent were in motor vehicle smashes. Another 25 per cent of these deaths were through self-inflicted injury or

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On the ship, rather than  
looking at it or reading  
it, they can become part  
of that myth.



suicide. In all, 76 per cent were due to accidents, poisonings and violence.

Health Department figures reveal that alcohol was a factor in the deaths of a quarter of males under 30 between 1990 and 1994. A 1997 survey shows that, on their day of heaviest consumption, 79 per cent of male drinkers consume at harmful levels. The average is a staggering 16 standard drinks.

Recent Health Department figures from a nationwide drug strategy survey show that 12 per cent of youngsters aged between 14 and 19 binge drink on a regular basis, compared with 5 per cent of adults. The study, which surveyed more than 2000 adolescents aged 14 to 19, showed 7 per cent of adolescents had intended to get drunk in the two weeks before being questioned.

And there are the games, such as "funnels", where alcohol is funnelled into the drinker's mouth, and the 100 Club, or Centurion, where contestants drink a 30ml shooter of alcohol a minute for 100 minutes, and which claimed the life of a 19-year-old male in Bunbury earlier this year.

These are dangerous years ... these years of trial, display and self-doubt.

But there are still healthy quests to be had. Or Learning Moments, as Greg Tonnison calls them. A specialist in outdoor education, Tonnison has spent most of his working life on board sail training ships. He is now Chief Executive Officer of Leeuwin Ocean Adventure. Its ship, Sail Training Ship Leeuwin II, provides the venue for such Learning Moments.

"Before industrialisation boys had more of a role to play," he said. "It was pretty clear-cut — they had certain things to learn. There are so many choices now."

"Outdoor experiences can provide extremely powerful impacts in terms of exploring their manhood. They can start acting out things they couldn't in their family and peer group. Experimenting with different behavioural styles. The ship is an excellent venue for that, as an experimental platform."

On board, boys face physical challenges and also have a "choice" of mentors in the regular crew, chosen as much for their leadership and motivational skills as for sailing ability. "It might be the captain or a watch leader — role models of manhood. Choosing mentors happens and you can see it. At the end of the voyage the 'trainees' take over the ship and you can see that modelling of different people."

Boys to Men by Stephen Scourfield

Source: "The West Australian", "Big Weekend", 22 May, 1999.

1. From the context of the article, give the meaning of the following words and phrases:

- ✱ mentor
- ✱ parameters
- ✱ rite of passage
- ✱ plethora
- ✱ a la carte
- ✱ chemical turmoil
- ✱ self-aggrandising
- ✱ language of descent
- ✱ futurist
- ✱ experimental platform
- ✱ archetype

2. What is the main idea of this piece of writing?

3. Make summary notes of the article following these guidelines:

**HEADING**  
Main idea of the article

1. Sub- MAJOR heading  
    ➤ Points relating to sub-heading 1.

2. Sub-heading  
    ➤ Points relating to sub-heading 2.

Continue in the above fashion incorporating as many sub-headings as you need for your notes.

Remember:

- ♣ Use only key words and phrases
- ♣ Select only important details
- ♣ Omit examples and illustrations
- ♣ Write in point form only

4. Write about  $\frac{1}{2}$  page of prose writing on what you think about the need for role models in the life of a teenager growing into adulthood. In your reflection include some personal experiences.

## **Some notes on expository texts**

### **Expository Texts**

Some students have had some difficulties working out what is meant by the term 'expository text'. You must know this term because questions might direct you to answer questions about it. Here is what the course description says about expository texts:

Expository print text: a form of text that is used to convey information. This category can include but is not limited to, feature articles, discussion essays, academic essays, newspaper articles, websites, blogs, reports, which are shaped to position their reader. Expository texts can be extended book length texts.

Expository writing: a form of writing which conveys primarily information.

Below is a definition from the old English course and some questions from past exams. You won't get questions exactly worded like this but it is still useful to be able to talk about these ideas.

### **Non-Fiction Texts**

Central to the study of non-fiction in this subject is the principle that non-fiction texts do not simply present facts or realities. Rather, each text presents particular attitudes to its subjects, and selects information and language appropriate to the presentation of these attitudes.

Students will present their understandings of the non-fiction texts they read in a variety of formal and informal writing and oral activities. Non-fiction texts are also significant in this subject as models for the students' own writing. In paying conscious attention to the techniques used in such texts, students will improve their abilities to select language, detail and structure appropriate to their subjects, audiences and purposes. To this end, they may be asked to model some of their writing on selected passages from non-fiction texts.

### ***Exposition***

Exposition is defined as writing that is intended primarily to inform, instruct or explain, as distinct from the non-fiction narrative writing studied in Year 11 English,

which intends primarily to relate events. Appropriate texts for this subject are those that present detailed ideas about and attitudes to events, issues or social groups.

Students will be taught to identify the ideas, propositions and arguments presented in an expository text, and to recognise the assumptions and values underlying them.

Students will study the language of each text, its selection of detail and its structure, including the structure of individual sections or chapters, as well as the overall structure of each text. They will be taught to consider how these features encourage particular responses in the reader.

### Some previous Exam Questions

#### Values and attitudes

'The key function of expository texts is to explore awkward questions deeply and critically.' To what extent do you agree or disagree with this statement? Support your answer by referring to at least one book length expository text or at least two shorter expository texts. (2002)

'Expository texts provide an ideal way to improve our understanding of the world around us.' Prepare a case for or against this statement, supporting your argument with examples from your reading of expository texts. (1997)

'Expository Texts are written to make a difference, to make the world a "better" place.' Respond to this statement by making detailed reference to at least one non-fiction expository text that you have studied. (2000)

Describe how selection of information and deliberate use of language have combined to convey specific attitudes towards the subject of non-fiction expository text that you have read. (You may not use a feature article) (1999)

Writers of expository texts often use a variety of techniques to persuade readers to change their attitudes towards an issue. Comment on this statement with reference to at least one expository text. (1998)

Chapters or sections of expository texts are better understood as parts of larger texts.' Discuss how your reading of a chapter or section of a book-length non-fiction expository text is enhanced by your knowledge of the text as a whole. (2001)